

SAD

Facial expressions

Facial expressions reveal much about a person's emotions (see pp.116–117). The eyes and the mouth, in particular, automatically respond to strong feelings, although people can consciously change their expressions to mask emotions.

DEFENSIVE

Posture

An aggressive posture tends to inflate a person's size. It may involve extending the arms, setting the feet far apart, and protruding the chest. The same postures may be used to invade others' personal space. In contrast, defensive postures are closed—folded arms, for example, are a classic indicator.



Gestures

Most body language is performed unconsciously, but we have more conscious control over our gestures, which are movements of the body used to convey meaning. There are four categories of gestures: symbolic (or emblematic); deictic (or indexical); motor (or beat); and lexical (or iconic). They might be used instead of speech or alongside it for emphasis. Some scientists believe that increasingly complex gestures evolved as the forerunners of speech, which now defines our species.

TYPES OF GESTURES



Symbolic

These are gestures that can be literally translated into words—for example, waving hello or making the “okay” sign. They are widely recognized in a given culture but may not be recognized beyond that culture.



Deictic

Deictic gestures involve pointing or otherwise indicating a concrete object, person, or more intangible item. Used with or without speech, they act like pronouns, meaning “this” or “that.”



Motor

This type of gesture is short and tied to speech patterns, such as moving the hand in time with speech, and is used for emphasis. Motor gestures contain no inherent meaning and are meaningless without accompanying vocalization.



Lexical

These gestures depict actions, people, or objects, such as miming throwing when telling a story about throwing a ball, or using your hands to depict an object's size. They usually accompany speech but contain meaning independently.

SIGN LANGUAGE

Sign language may appear to be a sophisticated type of body language, but it has more in common with speech. Studies show that when people sign, the same brain areas (see right) light up as when they speak. Sign language has grammar, and each gesture has a specific meaning, while body language is interpreted broadly.

